The Shri Rajput Karni Sena, self-proclaimed custodians of all things Rajput, were the first to take umbrage, not just with the character of the film—a saga of romance more than valour—but also its very name. Plain Prithviraj was an affront, Samrat Prithviraj, as the movie was subsequently renamed, was more befitting of their icon's stature. They had made the makers of *Jodha Akbar* and *Padmaavat* bend to Rajput will; in March 2020, led by national president Mahipal Singh Makrana, the Sena once again took up cudgels for the Rajput cause and marched towards Jamwa Ramgarh, where the shooting of the film had commenced. Once there, a familiar script played out: uproar, sloganeering and vandalism.

The retaliation, though, came from another quarter. It appeared surreptitiously on Twitter one day—May 7, 2021, to be precise—in the guise of a hashtag, #GurjaremperorPrithviraj Chauhan. The return of fire came only a few hours later, hashtagged #RajputemperorPrithvirajChauhan. And thus a new battleground opened up on social media—Gurjars versus the Rajputs.

Long burnished in Indian history text books as a brave Rajput warrior whose legendary exploits became the stuff of epic poetry, be it Kashmiri poet-historian Jayanaka's Sanskrit work *Prithvirajvijayammahakavyam* or Chand Bardai's *Prithviraj Raso* penned in the Brajbhasha, what has prompted the Gurjars to stake this belated claim, several centuries later, on the heritage of the 'last great Hindu emperor' in Colonel James Tod's reckoning, the vastness of whose kingdom was contained in its very name—Sapadalaksha or one and a quarter lakh villages? Education, if one is to go by Gujjar historian Jitesh Gujjar, who is associated

DISPUTED LEGACIES

Other historical personalities who are claimed by more than one community



EMPEROR ASHOKA

Kshatriya or Kushwaha?

On the birth anniversary of the 3rd century BCE ruler, the BJP assigned the responsibility of organising a grand celebration at his birthplace in Pataliputra, modern-day Patna, to Kushwaha leader Samrat Chaudhury. Uttar Pradesh deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya was a special invitee as, apart from being a Kushwaha, he also has Maurya in his name. Another Maurya leader, Keshav Dev, too, celebrated the occasion with great gusto in UP. "Ashoka was a king, so he was called Kshatriya," he says. "But we are from the same lineage. Our place in the *varna* system changed after we took to farming"



RAJA SUHAIL DEV

Pasis vs the Rajbhars

The Maharaja Suhail Dev Seva Samiti claimed that the raja was a Pasi in 2001. Rajbhars, on the other hand, cite the *Mirat-e-Masoodi,* Abdur Rahman Chishti's biography of Mahmud Ghazni, to claim that Suhail Dev was from the Bhartharu community. A statue, a postage stamp and then the foundation stone of a medical college named after the warrior, the BJP is doing it all to attract the Pasi and Rajbhar votes



RANA PUNJA

Rajput or Bhil?

The Bhils say he was born in Merpur, near modern Udaipur, in Rajasthan. Rajputs say Rana Punja, who fought alongside Maharana Pratap, is descended from the Bhojawat Solanki Rajputs. In the past few years, a statue war has erupted in southern Rajasthan, with the Bharatiya Tribal Party, the political front of the Bhil Parivar, insisting that any reference to the raja say Rana Punja Bhil